DIPLOMA PROGRAMME PRACTICE / HL / SET B

Psychology / Paper 1

Worked mark scheme · 90 minutes · 35 marks

Answer Questions 1–4 in Sections A and B. In Section C answer either Question 5 or Question 6. Use psychological knowledge and accurate terminology throughout.

Judge the whole response against the question-specific markband. Award zero for no creditworthy material. The worked answers illustrate one route; credit other scientifically defensible answers. Class-practical examples are illustrative.

SECTION A

Knowledge and understanding

QUESTION 1 / 4 MARKS

Explain how social categorisation can influence behaviour, using one example from social identity theory.

Worked response. Social categorisation sorts people into groups such as “our team” and “their team”. When membership contributes to self-concept, a favourable comparison can help maintain a positive social identity. A club member allocating a neutral training slot might favour a fellow member over an equally experienced outsider. The preference arises from salient group membership; hostility toward the other group is not required.

Credit. Accept another example that explicitly connects categorisation, identity and behaviour. Recognising a category without explaining any behavioural consequence is insufficient for the upper band.

Markband. 1–2: relevant content is partly described or the example is left unexplained. 3–4: a precise account of the idea explains how a suitable example illustrates it.

QUESTION 2 / 4 MARKS

Describe how one brain imaging technique can be used to investigate a relationship between brain activity and behaviour. Illustrate your answer with an example.

Worked response. Functional MRI can compare a blood-oxygen-level-dependent signal while a person performs a task and a matched comparison activity. For example, contrasting word generation with repeating familiar words can identify regions whose signal differs with additional language demands. The signal reflects a haemodynamic response related indirectly to neural activity. A difference shows an association with the task contrast; it does not show that one region alone produces the behaviour.

Credit. Accept another suitable brain imaging technique when the signal, comparison and example fit. A structural MRI image alone measures anatomy, so simply calling its bright areas active is inaccurate.

Markband. 1–2: relevant content is partly described or the example is left unexplained. 3–4: a precise account of the idea explains how a suitable example illustrates it.

SECTION B

Application to new situations

QUESTION 3 / 6 MARKS

An apprentice reads a familiar-looking warning label and immediately selects the usual valve. On an untimed check she notices that a single word reverses the instruction and changes her answer. When a second task occupies her attention, she is again likely to select the usual valve.

Explain how a dual processing model could account for the pattern of decisions.

Worked response. A familiar cue can trigger a rapid response based on past matches. The usual valve feels appropriate before the changed word is examined. With time and attention available, more effortful processing can compare the actual wording with the expected instruction and override the first response. The second task competes for the attention needed for that check, so the initial response is more likely to stand. The model distinguishes processes, not two separate anatomical systems.

Credit. The account should link more than speed to the case: recognition of a familiar cue, checking an exceptional detail and the effect of divided attention. Deliberation is not always correct and a quick decision is not always an error.

Markband. 1–2: a relevant idea is named or applied in a limited way. 3–4: mostly accurate theory explains some features of this case. 5–6: detailed, accurate theory explains the distinctive pattern or contrast in the situation.

QUESTION 4 / 6 MARKS

A child moves between two households. At one, relatives leave a shared dish untouched until the oldest guest begins, and praise the child for waiting. At the other, guests are encouraged to begin while food is hot. After several visits the child waits at the first home but begins promptly at the second, even when no adult gives an instruction.

Explain how enculturation could account for the child's different behaviour in the two households.

Worked response. Enculturation is learning the norms and meanings of a cultural setting through participation. Observing relatives wait and hearing approval supplies a model and feedback about respect. At the other home, beginning promptly is modelled as appropriate. Repeated participation makes the setting a cue for the locally expected behaviour. Acting without an instruction is consistent with learning a norm rather than simply obeying a present command.

Credit. Explain how social transmission operates in both settings. Different household practices do not establish that all members of two national cultures act alike. Observational learning or reinforcement earns credit when connected to acquiring and applying the norm.

Markband. 1–2: a relevant idea is named or applied in a limited way. 3–4: mostly accurate theory explains some features of this case. 5–6: detailed, accurate theory explains the distinctive pattern or contrast in the situation.

SECTION C

Conceptual essays · choose one

QUESTION 5 / 15 MARKS

Evaluate the claim that changing how people identify with a group is sufficient to change their behaviour towards members of another group. Refer to the concept of causality.

Worked argument. Social identity theory suggests that a salient shared identity can redraw the boundary between "us" and "them". Giving formerly separate teams a meaningful joint role could make helping a former outsider consistent with the new in-group norm. A rise in helping after a joint project would fit this mechanism, but identity change, repeated contact, rewards and opportunities to help all changed together.

Testing causality. A stronger comparison varies framing of the shared identity while holding opportunities, rewards and contact similar. Measure identification separately from actual helping, and check whether change persists after observation ends. Random allocation reduces prior group differences. Even an effect of the framing does not establish that identification is the sole mediator; participants may infer the expected behaviour.

Judgement. Identification is more likely to matter when the shared group is valued and its norms favour cooperation. Competition for a scarce resource or a hostile leadership norm can sustain exclusion despite a common label. A cause that contributes in one setting is not necessarily sufficient across settings. Accept other examples and conclusions supported by this distinction.

Markband. 1–3: isolated content with little bearing on the concept. 4–6: a mainly descriptive account with a partial conceptual link. 7–9: relevant knowledge and some analysis, but the argument or conclusion is incomplete. 10–12: developed critical analysis connects the concept, psychology and context and supports a judgement. 13–15: sustained, precise conceptual reasoning weighs competing interpretations and supports a nuanced judgement throughout.

QUESTION 6 / 15 MARKS

Discuss how the concept of measurement influences judgements about the effectiveness of a strategy for improving memory.

Worked argument. Repeated retrieval can strengthen access to learned information. Testing immediately with the same cues measures one kind of access. Recognition among familiar options can be aided by familiarity, while delayed free recall requires generating an answer without those prompts. A learner who recognises every practised item can still fail to retrieve it after a week or apply it in a new setting.

Evaluating the evidence. Compare retrieval practice with restudy for equal time, using parallel material and a delayed test. Vary the cue format to test transfer; a change in format alone can lower performance for both groups. Baseline knowledge, ceiling effects and inconsistent scoring can obscure change. Reliable scoring makes a comparison repeatable without proving that the outcome measures durable memory.

Judgement. A matching immediate test is informative if immediate performance is the aim. A claim about lasting learning requires converging evidence across intervals and tasks. The preferred measure therefore depends on the scope of the effectiveness claim, not simply which test yields the highest score.

Markband. 1–3: isolated content with little bearing on the concept. 4–6: a mainly descriptive account with a partial conceptual link. 7–9: relevant knowledge and some analysis, but the argument or conclusion is incomplete. 10–12: developed critical analysis connects the concept, psychology and context and supports a judgement. 13–15: sustained, precise conceptual reasoning weighs competing interpretations and supports a nuanced judgement throughout.